

MANAGED DETECTION & RESPONSE FOR K-12

A security team for every MERLIN division, *not just the ones that can staff one*

24/7 monitoring, investigation and response, fully managed by Canadian security analysts. Built and tested for the way school networks are actually run.

WHAT WE'LL COVER

Thirty minutes, five questions

01 What is the program?

How CIRA MDR is built, and what the managed SOC actually does.

02 Who is it built for?

Why K-12 needed its own version, and what we changed.

03 Does it cover our fleet?

Chromebooks, network gear and everything without an agent on it.

04 How does rollout work?

Three programs, one phased path, fixed pricing at each step.

05 What changes for the division?

The results a school can expect in the first year, and what it costs your team to get there.

PART ONE

Why schools, *and why now*

THE CHALLENGE

Attackers don't wait for the bell, *and they don't skip summer*

A school division holds student records, health data, payroll and payment systems on a network that has to stay open to thousands of unmanaged users. It is an enterprise attack surface run by a team of a few.

Alert fatigue and staffing gaps

Too many alerts, not enough people to read them.



Nothing watched after hours

Evenings, weekends, PD days and July. Nothing gets read until someone is back.



Tools you own but can't watch

The licences are paid for.
The console is nobody's job.



Slow, uncertain response

Without a team behind it, containment takes days instead of minutes.



WHY NOW

The public sector is already in the blast radius

55%

of MUSH-sector organizations
reported a cyberattack in the past
year

69%

cite data sovereignty as the most
important factor when sourcing a
security solution

78%

of Canadian organizations
increased cybersecurity budgets
by 10–25% in 2025

Sources: CIRA 2025 Cybersecurity Survey; Get Cyber Safe, *Canadian organizations are navigating cyber security* (2024).

WHO IT'S BUILT FOR

A school division is not a small enterprise. *It's a different problem.*

We built the K-12 program around four constraints that enterprise MDR quotes tend to ignore.

The fleet is Chromebooks

Most MDR vendors price per endpoint agent, then quietly exclude the tens of thousands of devices that can't run one.

Half the estate takes no agent at all

Switches, wireless controllers, firewalls, printers, cameras, building systems. All on the network, none of them installable.

The budget is fixed before the year starts

Consumption pricing and per-incident fees are unbudgetable in a division. The number has to hold for the fiscal year.

The data belongs to children

Student privacy obligations set a higher bar than most commercial deployments, and the answer has to survive a parent asking.

PART TWO

How the program *is built*

WHAT CIRA MDR IS

You have security tools. *Do you have a security team?*

CIRA MDR is two things sold as one: the CIRA XDR detection platform, and a Canadian analyst team watching it around the clock. The platform finds candidates. People decide what is real and act on it.

24/7 monitoring

Eyes-on-glass coverage on nights, weekends and the whole summer.



Active validation

An analyst confirms a threat is real before it reaches your inbox.



Human-led response

Containment guided by a person, with pre-agreed authority to act.



Canadian throughout

Telemetry, infrastructure and analysts stay in Canada. Billed in CAD.



HOW IT WORKS

Signals become action, *not alerts in a queue*

1

Signals

Telemetry is collected continuously across endpoints, network gear, identity, DNS, email and cloud.

2

Platform

CIRA XDR normalizes and correlates it, then flags what warrants a second look.

3

Analysts

Canadian analysts investigate, confirm whether it is real, and determine actual impact.

4

Action

The incident is contained on pre-agreed playbooks, and your team is told what happened and why.

SIGNAL, NOT NOISE

300 million events in. *A handful of real incidents out.*

300M+

raw events

~15,000

correlated detections

30–50

human reviews

0–5

actionable alerts for your
team

Every log from your firewall, endpoints, domain controllers, Microsoft 365 and Google Workspace flows into CIRA XDR. Analysts investigate what survives correlation, so your team only ever sees confirmed, high-risk incidents.

COVERAGE

We cover Chromebooks and the gear you can't install on. *A lot of vendors don't.*

If a quote only counts devices that accept an agent, it isn't covering your division. We put real R&D into the other two-thirds of a school network.

Chromebooks

- Monitored through Google Workspace and Chrome Enterprise admin telemetry, with no agent to deploy or maintain.
- Sign-in, device, and policy events correlated against the rest of the division's activity, not treated as a separate silo.
- Account compromise and credential abuse are visible whether the student is on campus or at home.

Agentless infrastructure

- Switches, wireless controllers, firewalls and routers monitored by log and flow collection, not installation.
- Printers, cameras, door controllers and building systems are seen as network participants, which is how they get abused.
- DNS-layer visibility across the division catches what never touches a managed device at all.

PART THREE

The managed *SOC*

THE TEAM BEHIND IT

Canadian analysts, *on the clock all year*

The SOC is staffed continuously, in Canada, with no offshore handoff at the end of a shift. Before go-live we agree in writing what analysts may do on their own and where they must call you first.

Staffed 24/7/365

Analysts on shift overnight, on weekends, over the holidays and through the summer. Not an on-call pager.

Agreed authority to act

Isolate a device, disable an account, block a domain. Which actions are pre-authorized is your decision, set during onboarding.

Reporting leadership can read

A monthly summary written for a superintendent and a board, not a console screenshot.

INTEGRATION

It works with what you already run. *Nothing gets replaced.*

MDR sits on top of the stack the division already paid for and finally puts someone in front of it.



Google Workspace for Education

Identity, sign-in and Chromebook telemetry.



Microsoft 365 and Entra ID

Mail, identity and conditional access events.



Your existing EDR and firewalls

Kept in place, ingested, and finally watched.



Content filtering and DNS

Including CIRA DNS Firewall where a division runs it.



Your ticketing system

Incidents land where your team already works.



Student information systems

Treated as crown-jewel infrastructure from day one.

OPERATIONS

The SOC runs *on the school calendar*

September

Thousands of devices come back onto the network in one week. Baselines are re-established rather than alarmed on.

Exam periods

Change freezes respected. Containment actions that would disrupt assessment get escalated to you first, not taken automatically.

Summer

The quietest months on your side are the busiest window for attackers. Coverage does not thin out when your team goes on leave.

Year-end

Mass account rollover and device re-imaging handled as planned change, not as a wave of anomalies.

Security monitoring *without surveilling students*

Data stays in Canada, on Canadian infrastructure, handled by Canadian staff. And the scope of what we look at is deliberately narrow.

What CIRA MDR sees

- OS and application logs: events and outcomes
- File changes: permissions, ownership, timestamps
- Process and network socket activity
- Configuration state and compliance drift

What it never sees

- File contents or encrypted data in transit
- Memory contents beyond audit surfaces
- Personal communications or web browsing
- Email content

PART FOUR

Rolling it out *with MERLIN*

THREE PROGRAMS

Start where the risk is. *Grow when the budget allows.*

Each program is fixed-price for the fiscal year. Moving up a step is a scope change, not a new procurement.

Program one

Critical infrastructure

The systems that stop the division if they stop: servers, identity, the student information system, core network and the admin systems that run payroll and records.

The floor. Below this there is no meaningful coverage.

Program two

Critical plus staff devices

Everything in program one, plus teacher and administrator laptops. The devices that hold marks, IEPs and student data, and the ones that have to keep working on Monday morning.

Where most divisions land.

Program three

Everything connected

The full estate. Student Chromebooks, network and wireless infrastructure, printers, cameras and building systems. If it has an IP address, it is in scope.

Full visibility, no blind spots left.

SCOPING

What should count as *critical infrastructure*?

The useful test is not what is expensive. It is what closes schools, exposes children, or stops payroll.

Almost always critical

- Identity: Entra ID, Google Workspace, directory services
- Student information and assessment systems
- Finance, payroll and HR
- Core network, firewalls and internet edge
- Backup and recovery infrastructure

Argued over, and usually should be

- Teacher and administrator laptops
- Transportation and bus routing
- Door access, cameras and building controls
- Parent communication and emergency notification
- Food services and payment processing

GETTING STARTED

How a MERLIN division comes online

Week 1–2

Scope

Inventory review, program selection, and a written definition of what is critical in your division.

Week 2–4

Connect

Telemetry sources onboarded: cloud tenants first, then network and endpoints. No forklift, no downtime.

Week 4–6

Tune

Baselines set against your normal, escalation paths and response authority agreed and documented.

Week 6 onward

Live

Full 24/7 coverage, monthly reporting, and a quarterly review with your account team.

MERLIN handles the commercial relationship. CIRA handles onboarding, the platform and the SOC.

BUDGET

One number, *set before the year starts*

Pricing is fixed per program and quoted through MERLIN. What matters for planning is what it does not do.

No per-incident charges

A bad month does not produce a surprise invoice. Response is included in the program.

No metered ingest

You are not billed by log volume, so nobody has to decide which sources to leave out to save money.

Quoted and billed in CAD

A multi-year US-dollar contract carries currency risk on top of cyber risk. Renewal cost shouldn't move with the exchange rate.

No new headcount required

The alternative to MDR is hiring and retaining a 24/7 team. For most divisions, that comparison is the whole business case.

THE END RESULT

What a division can expect *in year one*

Not a new console to learn. A shorter list of things that are your problem.

- **Threats caught outside business hours**

The incidents that used to be found on Monday are handled at 3am.

- **A defensible answer for the board**

Monthly reporting that shows what happened and what was done about it.

- **Cyber insurance questions you can answer**

24/7 monitoring and documented response are increasingly a condition of coverage.

- **A short, honest alert list**

Confirmed incidents only. Your team stops triaging and starts deciding.

- **Coverage of devices you had written off**

Chromebooks and agentless infrastructure inside the monitored estate, not outside it.

- **A budget line that holds**

Same number in March as in September.



NEXT STEPS

One hour, *your environment*

Book a technical session with a CIRA analyst. We walk your actual inventory, agree what counts as critical in your division, and show you exactly what MDR would be watching. No cost, no obligation.

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